

GUIDED-MISSILE DESTROYER

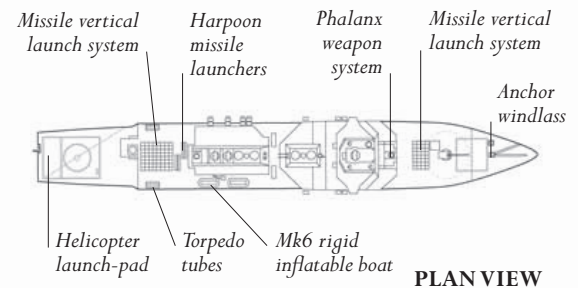
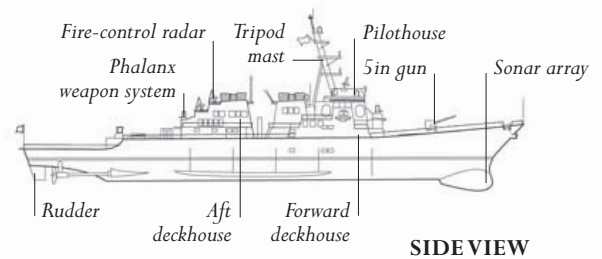
USS DONALD COOK

The US Navy's guided-missile destroyer *Donald Cook* saw action in the Iraq War. Deployed in Operation Iraqi Freedom in March 2003, it was among the first ships to launch strikes against Iraqi targets.

The *Donald Cook* and her fellow Arleigh Burke-class destroyers are among the most advanced surface warships in service today. Launched in 1997 and the 25th ship in the class, the *Donald Cook* belongs to Flight II, which embodies significant advances in armaments and electronics on earlier versions. The ship is packed with diverse weaponry, giving her what the US Navy calls "multi-mission offensive and defensive capabilities". The heart of the destroyer's offensive capabilities are the two Mk41 Vertical Launch Systems (VLS). These can fire anti-aircraft missiles, anti-submarine missiles, missiles for destroying other surface ships, and cruise missiles for

strike operations against land targets. The ship also has a launch-pad from which an attack helicopter can operate.

The destroyer's design is intended to maximize its chances of surviving. The Arleigh Burke class were among the first ships to incorporate "stealth" technology, with buried funnels and angled shapes that reduce their radar profile, as well as features to suppress infrared emissions. They were also the first all-steel American warships. Using steel rather than aluminium for the destroyer's superstructure reduces damage in the event of a missile hit. The *Donald Cook* has a crew of 30 officers and over 300 enlisted personnel.



▲ USS DONALD COOK

Despite being classed as a destroyer, *Donald Cook* is over 150m (500ft) long and displaces 8,400 tons, making her similar in size to many World War II cruisers.

DECK FEATURES



▲ ANCHOR CHAIN

The two anchors are carefully positioned so that they do not strike the large sonar bulge on the ship's hull as they are lowered and raised.



▲ HELICOPTER LANDING-LIGHTS

Green lights indicate a good approach, amber signal caution, and red mean that an incoming helicopter is too low. Flashing reds tell the pilot to abort the landing.



▲ HELICOPTER LANDING-PAD

The ship can embark and refuel a Sikorsky SH-60 Seahawk helicopter for search and attack missions or for transporting personnel and cargo.

▼ DECK PROFILE

Compact weaponry, some of it concealed, gives the deck a rather bare look. Later ships in the class have a covered hangar forward of the landing-pad.



▲ CHAFF AND DECOY LAUNCHER

The Super Rapid Bloom Offboard Chaff system launches chaff and infrared decoys to confuse enemy missiles and fire-control systems.

